THE CONDOTTIERI

In the 14th and 15th centuries, the wars fought in northern Italy were dominated by companies of mercenaries led by commanders known as "condottieri" – from the "condotta" or contract of service that they would negotiate with their employers. The condottieri provided armed forces for city states such as Milan, Florence, Venice, and Genoa, which had grown rich on trade and manufacture but had no substantial military forces of their own. The first of these condottieri were rootless knights from outside Italy, hailing from countries such as Germany, Spain, Hungary, and England. They were later supplanted by Italians, similarly seeking to make their fortunes through the profession of arms.



Brigandine
Worn chiefly by the foot soldiers in condottieri bands, the brigandine was a light sleeveless body armour of canvas and steel plates faced with rich material, in this case crimson velvet, which has all but perished.

BUSINESS IS BUSINESS

The condottieri were entrepreneurs with a wholly cynical attitude to their profession. The mercenary companies that they assembled – typically consisting of a few thousand knights and foot soldiers – would fight for whoever paid them and were notorious for changing sides at short notice. All, at times, fought against cities that had previously employed them. Although they liked to make a good show on the battlefield, wearing superb suits of armour, they avoided any hint of a fight to the death. They could be vicious in the massacre of civilians, but backed off from serious clashes with other mercenaries that might cost their men's lives. They tended instead to bribe the opposition to give way – or, preferably, to be bribed themselves.



Italian sallet
This fine example of a sallet, a style of helmet that came into fashion in the mid-15th century, was made in Milan around 1480.

Yet some condottieri won great renown. The English knight Sir John Hawkwood, leader of the White Company, died a wealthy man in Florence in 1394 and had his equestrian portrait painted as a fresco in the city's cathedral. Some of the leading condottieri developed political ambitions, the most successful founding ruling dynasties. Thus Francesco Sforza, himself the son of a mercenary captain, fought in a dizzying series of wars for and against the Pope, Milan, Florence, and Venice (among others) before establishing himself as Duke of Milan in 1450.

From the late 15th century onward, much of Italy was fought over by the armies of France and Spain, assisted by Swiss and German mercenaries. These forces showed up the military deficiencies of the Italian condottieri bands, so that by the mid-16th century the tradition had died out.

MUSLIM WARRIORS

The invasion of Palestine by Christian armies at the end of the 11th century was a shock to the Islamic world. It provoked a revival of the spirit of *jihad* (religious war) in a series of counter-offensives through the following two centuries. The Kurdish-born ruler of Egypt, Saladin, recaptured Jerusalem for Islam after decisively defeating a Christian army at Hattin in 1187. Only the arrival of forces from Europe led by King Richard the Lionheart of England and Philip Augustus of France enabled a crusader presence to survive in the Holy Land.

Divisions between the neighbouring Muslim states gave the Christians a reprieve until the Mamluks, slave soldiers of Turkish origin, overthrew their masters and seized power in Egypt in 1260. Under their inspired general Baybars, the Mamluks inflicted a series of crushing defeats upon the Christians, as well as triumphing over the Mongols at the battle of Ain Jalut. The crusaders were effectively beaten well before the fall of Acre in 1291 brought their presence in Palestine to an end.

Muslim armies used broadly the same military technology as their Christian opponents, but their tactics were completely different. Unlike European knights, they had no special liking for the cavalry charge or close-quarters combat, tending to avoid pitched battle until their opponents had been fatally weakened or lured into an encirclement. They made great use of mounted archers fighting as skirmishers, who would inflict losses from a distance, then make their escape if the Christian knights attempted to charge. Muslim cavalrymen wore significantly less armour than the Christians and were thus better adapted to fighting in a hot climate. In general, prosperous Muslim states such as Egypt, fighting near to home, were able to assemble far larger armies than the Christians could ever field, ensuring their victory in the longer term.



Saladin's army
Despite religious enmity, the crusaders recognized Muslim warriors as worthy and chivalrous opponents. They were represented by many European artists as dignified and pious.